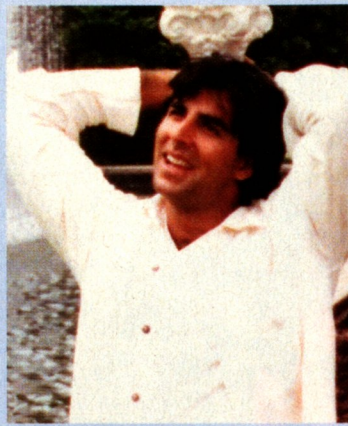


All-round Actor

The comic action star can dance and romance too

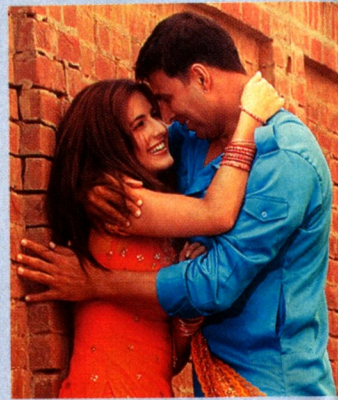
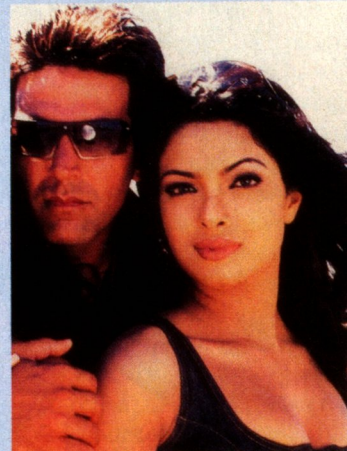


MOHRA, 1994: The best of the B-film genre, showcased his onscreen chemistry with then girlfriend Raveena Tandon.



DIL TO PAGAL HAI, 1997: Small role in huge Yash Chopra film. Gave him new-age sensitive guy image despite the big hair.

ANDAAZ, 2003: Played his favourite character Raj Malhotra, romanced two women and married the widow.



NAMASTEY LONDON, 2007: Wore orange hair and kajal. Made desi look cool, and consolidated his growing overseas appeal.

IN THE RISKED BUSINESS OF ACTING, KUMAR TOOK A BIG RISK IN *KILAKKEE*, A MAN SEXUALLY ASSAULTED BY A WOMAN IN 1977

Manoj Kumar redux pulled the crowds into the theatres.

Namastey London also consolidated what was becoming clear in 2005: that Kumar had a diaspora audience which saw him as the modern heir to Dharmendra's Punjab *da puttar* mantle. By then he had worked on his voice modulation ("I realised I didn't have to ape Amitabh Bachchan. I could just vary my own voice"), his looks (he ensured his hairstyle would change with every film), and his attitude. He was ready to take a risk, to make a fool of himself if need be, even, unthinkable for a Bollywood hero, look less than a man (in *Aitraaz* when Priyanka Chopra's Demi Moore-inspired she-wolf is trying to paw him, he rejects her almost wimpishly). It is this neediness to be liked, this desperation to be accepted that audiences like in actors, and usually reward. Hey, if a guy is willing to go on a limb, why not give him a hand?

Kumar has also done all this by remaining an outsider. He has rarely got to work with the established directors (there are no Karan Johars and Sanjay Leela Bhansalis beating down his door) and has instead outgrown the tinpan alley sensibilities of Abbas-Mustan and Suneel Darshan, to work with a series of debutant directors, whether it is Shah in *Aankhen* (an association that has yielded three hits) or Shirish Kunder in *Jaan-e-Mann*. It has taught him a new way of looking at his work and allowed him even to experiment with traits (the donkey laughter in *Jaan-e-Mann* and the foxy lecherousness in *Heyy Babyy*). But it is master craftsmen like Raj Kumar Santoshi and Priyadarshan who have allowed him to develop his comic skills. Remembers Priyadarshan, who's directed him in *Hera Pheri*, *Garam Masala* and the forthcoming *Bhool Bhulaiya*: "When I took his first few shots in *Hera Pheri*, where I was strongly advised against casting him and Suniel Shetty, he had to do it 16 times before he got it right."

In all this, he has, oddly for a man once known for the women—Pooja Batra, Raveena Tandon, Shilpa Shetty, et al—he dated, sometimes simultaneously, become the family pin-up. He says about his male bimbo image: "There were never more than seven-eight women in my life. I was not married. What's wrong with that?" Now, he's the doting father and adoring husband. He takes care of his son when his wife, former actor Twinkle Khanna who is now a successful interior designer, is travelling on work, down to the massage, bathing, feeding and playing. "I think he's unconsciously echoing his dad's dedication to him," says Twinkle, as Kumar recalls his late father, a former army man who joined UNICEF, turning up with water bottle in hand, to watch him play volleyball or practise martial arts while he took his morning walk. His father is the one who encouraged him to dream big, paid the Rs 3,500 needed to travel to Bangkok, where an uncle lived, and where he learnt Thai kickboxing for five years. The childhood appears to have been straitened by money—for many years, the family lived in Sion at a rent of Rs 100 a month before shifting to a two-bedroom flat in Lokhandwala—but was completely devoted to Bruce Lee.

Having worked enough for money, he now wants a little bit of history—even if it's action history. "I fought Undertaker in *Khiladiyon ka Khiladi*, did cable work for *Awara Paagal Deewana*, parkour for the Thums Up ad and now I'm learning a new kind of martial arts for *Made in China*. I want to take Hindi action cinema to a new level," he says. As for the craft of acting, he's still honing it, observing how audiences react to movies (he watches every new film in the theatre by Saturday) and trying to understand the director's vision. Priyadarshan says Kumar has now lost his inhibitions in front of the camera. "Like Mohanlal, he doesn't need to act now, he just needs to be." That's the stuff of popcorn bliss and technicolour dreams. ■